

2. Organisation

The organisation trait relates to all things structural. In the process of learning, students are exposed to different text types and forms, but they also need to be explicitly taught how to organise their ideas within these text structures.



In a narrative text, students learn how to develop a plot with a complication and resolution, or how to use an “e” structure to create an engaging hook in the present moment. When learning about poetry, they learn that a sonnet contains a shift in meaning in the volta, or that a haiku must contain a pause.

If we set a history task where students write a news article to show their understanding of a fictional event, they need to understand the “reverse pyramid” structure.

In Science, students are taught how to sequence information in a scientific report.

In many subject areas, students are expected to write expository, analytic or persuasive essays. Some learning areas have variations in how they expect these to be structured, but it's still important to have a shared language across learning areas.

Common language:

Mentor text	An example of a text that students examine and use as a model for their writing. A mentor text might or might not be annotated to point out the language and structure used.
Contention	The overall idea presented in a persuasive or analytic text.
Intention	The effect or impact the writer hopes to achieve by writing a text.
Argument	A series of claims that lead to a conclusion/prove a contention.
Claim	A statement that is presented as true, usually supported by evidence.
Aristotelean argument	An argument where all claims and evidence directly support the contention.
Rogerian argument	An argument that presents both claims and counterclaims to arrive at a compromise conclusion.
Toulmin argument	An argument that assesses whether a series of claims is true or false.
TEEL	A basic structure for an essay paragraph. TEEL should be used consistently throughout the school.
Paragraph	A set of related sentences that focus on one key idea. In essay writing, “paragraph” must not be confused with “argument” or “claim”. <i>For example, a VCE level essay might contain three separate arguments, but it could contain seven or eight paragraphs.</i>
Topic sentence	The first sentence of a paragraph that states the idea or claim.
Link statement	The last sentence in a paragraph that connects the explanation back to the contention or essay prompt. <i>Note: the purpose of a link sentence is not to link to or introduce the next argument.</i>

Scaffolding students' writing structures

Regardless of whether we're assessing the structure of students' writing, we should still provide worked examples and explicit guidelines about how to organise their ideas.

Scaffolds might include:

<u>Annotated mentor texts</u>	Mentor texts are imperative, but an annotated version explicitly shows how the writer has organised their ideas into sections and paragraphs. Some students don't have the text knowledge to understand how to follow topic sentences and subheadings, so this skill sometimes needs to be taught.
<u>Reverse outlining tasks</u>	Students are given a <u>specialty formatted mentor texts</u>, whereby they <u>create their own annotations</u> to unpack the structure and ideas. <i>Note: also an excellent drafting/revision strategy.</i>
<u>Structure strips</u>	A thin strip of paper that contains a guide of how to structure a given text type.
<i>Partial writing tasks</i>	Students are given part of the text, and have to write one section. <i>In Science, students are given a partially completed experiment report, where the introduction and method are completed, and students complete the results and conclusion.</i> <i>In Humanities, students are given an introduction, one argument and a conclusion, and they have to write the second and third arguments.</i> <i>In English, students are given an explanation sentence with embedded evidence, and they have to write the topic sentence and link statement. Or vice versa.</i>
<u>Collaborative writing</u>	
<i>Frankenwriting</i>	<i>Either as a whole class using groups and collaborative documents, or by using a gamified platform like <u>frankenstories</u>.</i>